Making the impossible possible. It's a challenge Narendra Modi regularly sets for himself and works steadfastly towards achieving. In the 2014 general election, at a time when the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) tally had never crossed 182 seats, Modi led his party to a superlative 282-seat victory, and the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) to 336 seats in the 543-member Lok Sabha. This was the first time in 30 years—since Rajiv Gandhi piloted the Congress to a 414-seat win in 1984—that any party had won a simple majority on its own. Modi worked his magic a second time in 2019, improving the BJP's previous tally to 303 seats and the NDA's to 352. This time, he is staking his claim on two historic feats. The lesser peak: drawing level with Jawaharlal Nehru by taking his party to a third consecutive majority on its own. And the real Everest: doing so with 400 seats, equalling Rajiv Gandhi's record.

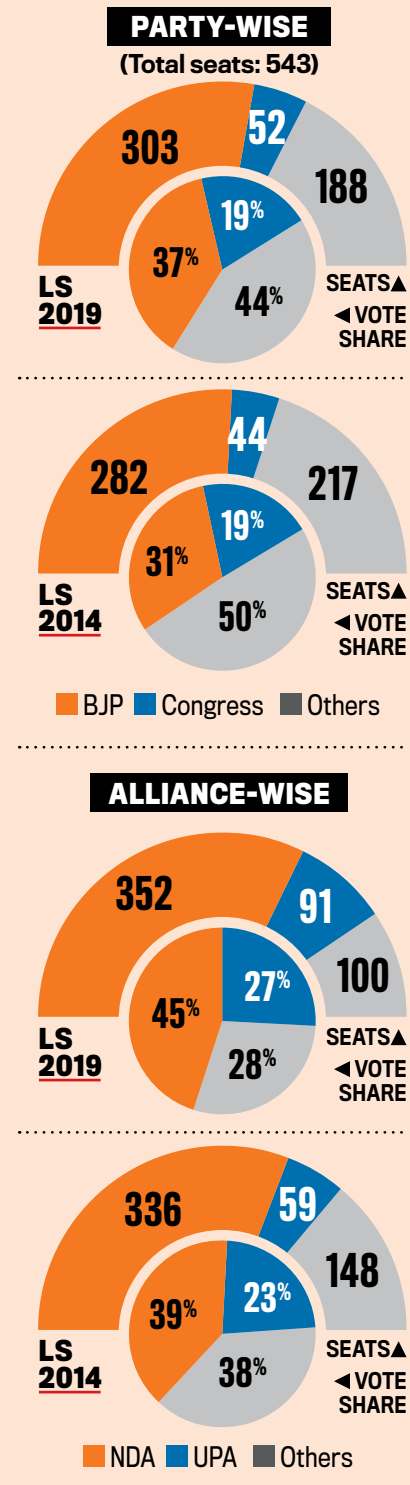
Modi announced his intention on February 5, just days before the final session of the 17th Lok Sabha. All he had to say was *'Ab ki baar...'* and his partymen provided the resounding chorus—*'Char sau paar'* (400-plus). The slogan marked the beginning of Modi and the BJP's election campaign. But even as they set themselves the seemingly impossible task, the prime minister and his core team of leaders must be well aware of just how tough it is to translate that intent into reality. While the BJP's vote share was 37.3 per cent in 2019 and the NDA's 45 per cent, it was still three percentage points short of the 48 per cent vote share the Congress netted in 1984 when it won 400-plus seats. This means that not only does the BJP have to add nearly 70 seats to its own tally, it also has to ensure that its NDA allies—who won 49 seats in 2019—retain their tally or improve it. Unlike in 1984, when Indira Gandhi's assassination triggered a massive sympathy wave for the Congress, Modi must generate a whole typhoon to carry his alliance past the 400 mark. **Here are five major strategies that the BJP and its allies in the NDA are relying on in their quest for 400 seats.**

1 GUARDING FORT BJP

Psephologist Amitabh Tiwari has coined a catchy acronym for the strategy he believes the BJP and the NDA should follow for Mission 400-plus. He calls it the Prabhu R.A.M. Plan—for 'Regain, Attain and Maintain'. The 'Maintain' part is critical to the NDA's quest in Tiwari's estimation, since the BJP has to have a 100 per cent strike rate in the 303 seats it won in 2019, while its allies in the NDA, who have dwindled in numbers since, have to win at least 30 of the 49 seats they got last time. What gives the BJP and its NDA allies confidence is that in 2019, they swept Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Jharkhand,

THE JOURNEY TOWARDS 400

In 2019, the BJP had gained 21 seats and the NDA 16 seats over their 2014 tally. There was also a six percentage point uptick in their vote share



Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY